Every prime minister is entitled to an extended honeymoon period, especially one who has scored such an emphatic victory. ‘Achhe Din Aane Wale Hain’ was Modi’s caller tune in the 2014 general elections. The Modi juggernaut was driven by an overarching sentiment of ‘hope’, the belief that the moment he was elected happy days of high growth, low inflation and strong, corruption-free governance would return. Hope brings with it a rising tide of expectations. When price rise remained stubborn in the first few weeks of the new government and tomato prices shot up, my driver asked me, *‘Sir, woh achhe din ka kya hua?’* (What happened to the promise of good days?) When there was no ‘big bang’ announcement in the Modi government’s first budget, his critics were quick to question his intent to reform. ‘Chidambaram’s budget with saffron lipstick,’’ was noted columnist Swaminathan Aiyar’s rather caustic verdict. When the Indian government blocked a WTO agreement by sticking to its stand on food subsidies, Modi admirer and right-wing economist Surjit Bhalla remarked angrily, ‘A leader, operating from a position of one of the most voted governments in Indian history, should be making policy with conviction, not emulating tactics of a defunct government.’

Truth is, Modi as prime minister has so far been more cautious than he was as a campaigner, the courage to usher in drastic reform less in evidence. Perhaps he doesn’t see himself as a Margaret Thatcher-like figure, as some of his supporters would like him to be—someone who will dismantle the Indian state in a manic urge for privatization. Perhaps he is more of an efficient, project-driven CEO—bullet trains and smart cities are his ideas for a new India, not labour reform or disinvesting PSUs.

As a resilient politician who has built a career with single-minded determination over several years of highs and lows, Modi likes to see himself, as they say in cricket, as a ‘*lamba race ka ghoda*’ (ready for the long haul). ‘My government is here for five, if not ten years—why are you judging me on the first 100 days?’ he asked an industrialist who met him. A close aide told me that it was no different when he first took over as chief minister in Gujarat. ‘He would like to fully familiarize himself with the